

8.1 Anti-Virus

Why is it that the “anti” prefix has failed to gain the limelight in the domain of open source? We quote from the Web site of OpenAntiVirus (OpenAV), one of the pioneers in the field: “OpenAntiVirus is not just another virus scanner to put on a computer! OpenAntiVirus is a platform for people seriously interested in anti-virus research, network security and computer security to communicate with each other, to develop solutions for various security problems, and to develop new security technologies. “

8.1.1 The Movement Today

That statement does the job for potential white hats who intend to stop the baddies in their tracks. Unfortunately for home users, it sounds discouraging. It is true that the research is in a nascent stage, with many such tools in their alphas, but there have been some surprise discoveries. Perhaps the most active and widespread tool in use today is ClamAV, a creation of Tomasz Kojm. As the project leader, he looks back to his childhood days and explains how he had raised a clam hoping to find a big shiny pearl inside its shell. Unfortunately the clam died closed, but down a few years, Kojm had found his pearl, and named it ClamAV. The 2006 SourceForge.net Community Awards declared ClamAV the runner-up in the security arena.

While most proprietary “anti” utilities seem to have bagged one award or the other, ClamAV is a successor to the now almost-defunct OpenAV project. ClamAV was earlier an add-on to the latter, which was coded in an interpreted language, Java. The immense popularity of the OpenAV edition inspired Kojm to make his own daemon application that was free from the overheads associated with Java. The resulting version of ClamAV sported both a command-line scanner and a virus database auto-updater, unlike its predecessor.

8.1.2 The Comparison

The obvious question is, where exactly do ClamAV and its clones stand in the real world?